Never Protected me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/58127197.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Characters:
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Child Abuse, Hurt No Comfort, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Life in the Horde (She-Ra), Abusive Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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by unicorn_sparkles2006

Summary

according to Catra, Adora never protected her. according to Adora, that was all she ever did.

Catra stumbled into the barracks disoriented and smelling like burnt fur. Adora could only stare at her in horror, no words leaving her mouth.

Catra glared at her friend through tear stained eyes and walked past her, climbing up to the top bunk.

Catra never slept in her own bed, she only went up there when she was upset, mostly at Adora.

"Catra," Adora finally found her voice, a slight lisp escaping due to her newly lost front tooth.

"Don't, Adora," Catra said coldly, not looking down at Adora. "It's time for your meeting now."

Adora didn't think she could ever find the words to describe her feelings for Shadow Weaver. They were just kids, but that didn't matter. Shadow Weaver had taken a hatred to Catra, and a-well, Adora wasn't quite sure what Shadow Weaver thought of her.

But, Adora knew that Catra should not be sitting up there in that top bunk, scared and hurt. Adora had supposedly taken her punishment last night, burns from Shadow Weaver's lightning still raw on her skin.

Shadow Weaver always promised Adora that she wouldn't hurt Catra. But, Shadow Weaver never kept a promise.

Sometimes it would work. Adora would take Catra's punishment, lie that she was training, and watch the next day as Catra smiled that her meeting went well. Well, that Shadow Weaver didn't hurt her as bad. But, Shadow Weaver was unpredictable. If Catra did something else, said or did the wrong thing. There wasn't much Adora could do.

She'd always try her hardest though. She'd take Shadow Weaver's burning gaze away from Catra, her own begging for a promise that was never kept.

Adora walked to the Black Garnet Chamber seething. It wasn't fair. Shadow Weaver promised. Adora didn't train for hours and take the hits meant for Catra for nothing.

When she got there, Shadow Weaver smiled at her, her mask illuminated by the light from the Black Garnet. Adora couldn't help but shudder.

"Adora," Her voice was soft, almost comforting. It only made Adora more angry.

"No," Adora's voice was sharp. "You promised you wouldn't hurt Catra, but you did anyways."

"Adora," Shadow Weaver warned, getting closer to Adora's small figure.

Adora really knew how this always played out. She could lie a million times to Catra. Lie that she didn't know how the red lightning felt against her skin. Lie that her bruises were from training. Lie that Shadow Weaver never hurt her. She was just training, she was always training. And Catra, Catra always believed every word of it.

"You always break your promise," Adora tried not to cry. Shadow Weaver always said not to show weakness, that the weak had no place in the horde.

"Oh, Adora," Shadow Weaver tucked Adora's hair behind her ear. "Why do you get so caught up on her, that insolent beast?"

"She's my friend," Adora's voice was desperate. "I promised to look out for her."

Adora heard the slap before she felt the sting on her cheek. She looked up at Shadow Weaver, involuntarily tears filling her eyes.

"You don't need her to drag you down," The Black Garnet flickered behind Shadow Weaver, its power begging to be used.

“We look out for each other,” A sob escaped Adora’s mouth, making Shadow Weaver’s eyes narrow.

“Do you really believe that, Adora?” Their faces were now inches away. Adora could feel Shadow Weaver’s hot breath. “You are always there for her, but where is she now, when you need her?”

“She’s hurt! You hurt her!”

Shadow Weaver’s tounge clicked, Adora had obviously answered wrong. “Are you sure you really want to keep taking her punishment?”

Adora nodded, swallowing a lump in her throat.

Shadow Weaver’s hand moved across Adora’s shoulder with a hum. “Ok, but I have a punishment just for you first.”

Adora didn’t make it back to the barracks until late that night, hours after everyone was asleep. She sighed as Catra was still on the top bunk, probably still upset. Her whole body ached as she walked to her buck, willing herself not to cry. Her head pounded along with her heartbeat, her bruised ribs ached, and her skin felt raw from the Black Garnet’s magic.

Another sob attempted its way out, making Adora make a sound that almost sounded like a snort. The bunk above her rustled in reaction. Catra must have heard her come in.

Sure enough, she saw mismatched glowing eyes peering down at her. “‘Dora?” Catra’s voice was sleepy.

“I was training,” The lie came easily. Adora knew Catra wouldn’t ask any questions. Adora knew that Catra would forget her own concern in the morning. And worst of all, Adora knew she would do it all again.

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